“The Other” in Simone de Beauvoir’s *The Second Sex*

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The Second Sex

- Key Question: **What is a woman?**
  - Debunking “Eternal Feminine”
  - Traditional definitions:
    - Biology
    - psychology
    - social roles
  - Viewed as insufficient by Beauvoir



Ludwig Karsten. *Adam and Eve*. 1899, Oil on Canvas.

Existentialist connection

Terrain:

- Existence precedes essence
- Humans are free, but situated
- Influence from Sartre



Beauvoir extends and applies these ideas to gender. Questioning whether ‘woman’ is a fixed essence (existence) or constructed.

“The Other”



Definition:

- Subject = autonomous, neutral, essential
- Other = relative, dependent, inessential

Structure:

- Man = Subject
- Woman = Other

“The Other” is not just a difference, but a hierarchal relation

Asymmetrical Relationship

- Human Identity formed through Self vs. Other
- Usually reciprocal -> both groups can be subject

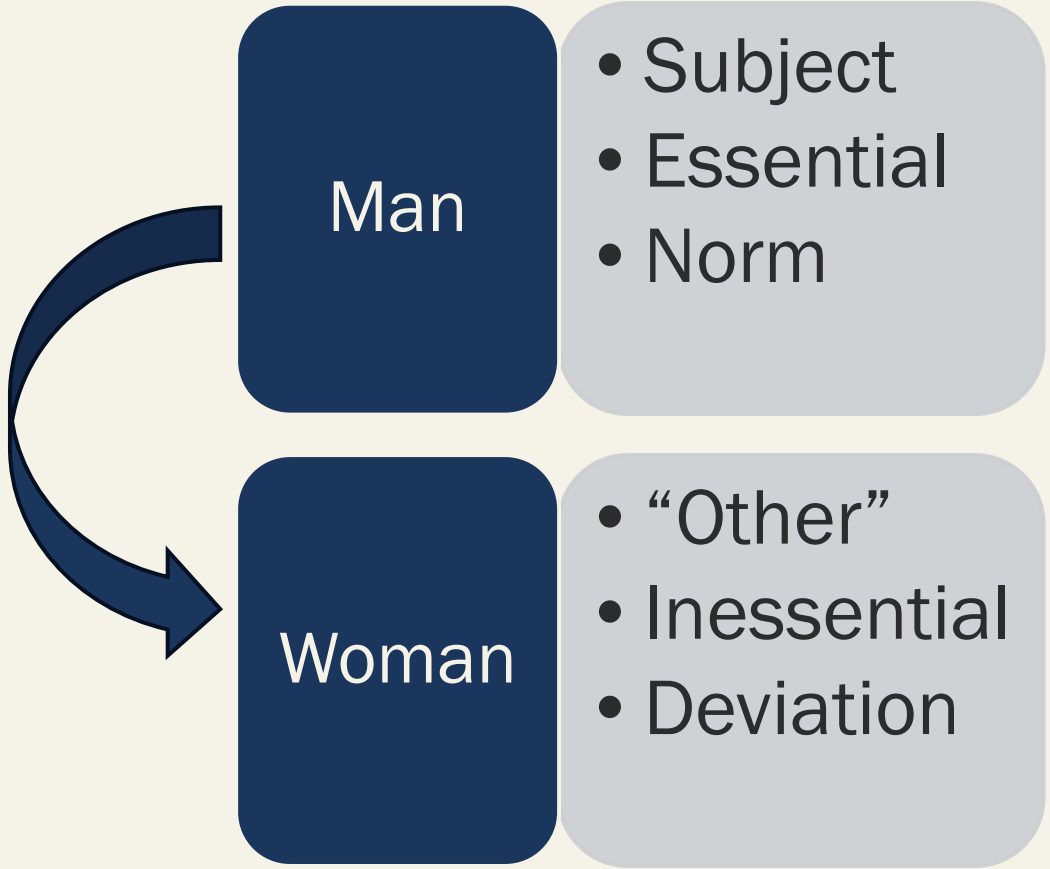
Beauvoir:

- Gender (sex) is different -> no reciprocity

Man = Universal Human

Woman = Defined relative to man

The Essential



- Man represents humanity
- Woman is treated as secondary and derivative to man

Result: Woman is denied full subjectivity.

Construction of “The Other”

- The hierarchy is not biological destiny
  - Critique of the “eternal feminine”
  - Basic essence of femininity
  - “She is the womb”(3).

- Sexual difference -> turned into inequality
  - Social, Historical production of bias
  - Appears natural, not



Edvard Munch. *Dive at Vaterland*. 1882(3), Oil on Canvas.

Glossary Entry

"The Other":

The Concept of "the Other" is used to describe the asymmetrical relation between men and women. While human identity is formed through this sort of opposition, these relations are typically reciprocal; to which Beauvoir argues, that sexes are an exception: as man positions himself as the universal subject while woman is defined only in relation to him. Resulting in woman being not recognized as an autonomous subject but as the inessential "Other". This condition did not occur out of natural consequence or biology, but through historically produced structure that presents itself as universal.

Works Cited

Beauvoir, Simone De. "Introduction." *The Second Sex.* Trans. Constance Borde and Malovany-Chevallier. New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1949. 3–17. Print.

Karsten, Ludwig. *Adam and Eve*. 1899, Oil on Canvas, Munch Museum, Oslo.

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